WORLD | 970 ACTIVE CASES | 17 DEATHS

It was only on 20 January 2020 that COVID-19 infection became national news in Chinese media and President Xi Jinping issued his first public comment on the situation revealing the scale of the outbreak. He stated that the outbreak 'must be taken seriously' and that every possible measure must be pursued to control it.[22] On an instinct, on 22 January, Vikram Misri, the Indian ambassador to China, advised his team to start preparing to evacuate Indians from the Hubei province. This would entail establishing exactly how many Indians resided in Hubei and where—the challenge was daunting since Indians were not required to register with the embassy and with popular social media channels like Facebook and Twitter blocked in China, outreach would be difficult. The next day, he attended a reception hosted by the embassy on the occasion of Republic Day, in which the Chinese vice foreign minister Luo Zhaohui was the chief guest, and was attended by several Chinese dignitaries and members of the Beijing-based diplomatic community. It was at this event that Misri heard hushed and off-the-record talk of the true scale of the infection and relayed his concern back to the Ministry of External Affairs in India, solidifying his stance on the need to evacuate Indians in the province.[23] The Indian embassy had planned to host a larger Republic Day ceremony on 26 January but announced on Twitter on 24 January that it stands to be cancelled. 'In view of the evolving situation due to the coronavirus outbreak in China as well as the decision of the Chinese authorities to cancel public gathering and events, @EOIBeijing has also decided to call off the Republic Day reception scheduled to be held @EOIBeijing on January 26th.'[24]

By this time, there were several travel-related cases detected in the US, Thailand, South Korea and Japan. In China, the death toll stood at 25, with confirmed cases at 830, including 26 cases reported in Beijing. China had by then locked down eight cities, including Wuhan, to prevent the virus from transmitting.

On 24 January, the Indian mission in China launched hotlines to track Indians based in Wuhan and provide psychological support by asking about their welfare in terms of supply of essential items.[25]

Meanwhile, Misri was constantly communicating with the secretary of External Affairs, Vijay Keshav Gokhale on the urgency to evacuate Indians. Gokhale was further communicating with the PMO and External Affairs